the façade of a strong strategic partnership. Russia's neutrality on South China Sea disputes and its outreach to Indo-Pacific countries have been mentioned. On its part, though China extended political support to Russia after the Crimea annexation, it did not endorse the Russian action and went on to exploit the breakdown in Ukraine–Russia relations to strengthen defence cooperation with Ukraine. Despite official Chinese rejection of Western sanctions, Chinese companies have been wary of exposure to Russia, investing only in projects of strategic value to China, mainly in the Arctic. China has ignored the BRI–EaEU cooperation agreement and pursued projects bilaterally with EaEU countries, avoiding Russian influence. Moreover, BRI connectivity projects have taken a southern route to Europe through Central Asia and the Caucasus, bypassing Russia.[28]
The sustainability of the current US course on Russia remains an open question. The latest US National Security Strategy describes Russia and China as contesting the "geopolitical advantages" of the US and trying to change the international order in their favour. The implicit assumption is that concurrently confronting both "revisionary" powers is a sustainable strategy. China's military power and economic reach make it a formidable adversary, even without adding Russia's nuclear strength and geographical advantages. The transatlantic alliance has been weakened by multiple fault lines within Europe. Geopolitical logic should arguably push the United States towards a new "Kissinger moment", settling for a (limited) accommodation with Russia to focus its energies on the Chinese challenge. Russia might weigh the advantage of such a truce against the increasing inequality in its China partnership. There is no definitive indication of such a shift in US strategic thinking, though US–Russia consultation and coordination on Afghanistan and Syria (albeit interspersed with harsh rhetoric on Ukraine) and President Trump's